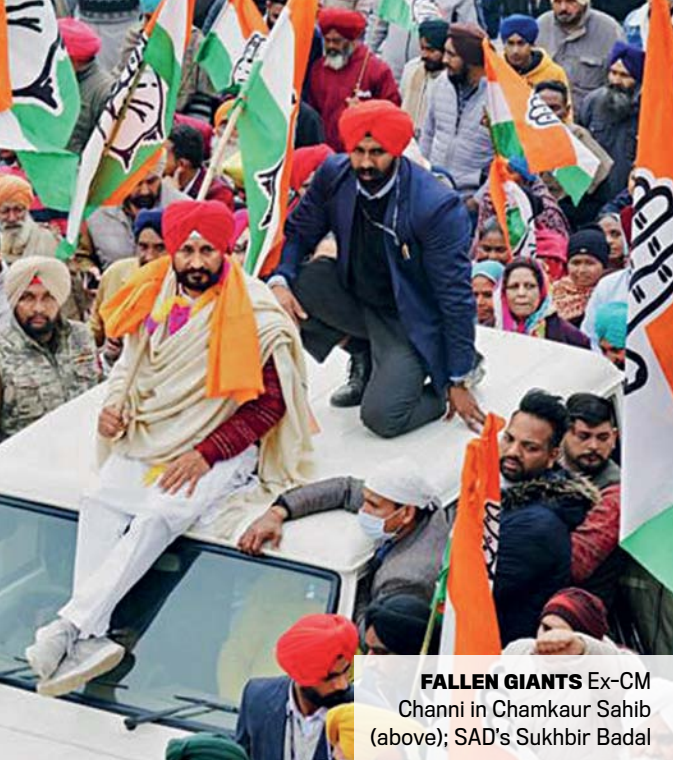




FALLEN GIANTS Ex-CM Channi in Chamkaur Sahib (above); SAD's Sukhbir Badal

elections as big names in Punjab's politics tasted dust. The list included, among others, sitting chief minister Charanjit Channi, who lost from both Chamkaur Sahib and Badhaur constituencies; Punjab Congress chief Navjot Sidhu, who lost in Amritsar East; Parkash Singh Badal, evicted from his traditional seat, Lambi; his son and SAD party chief Sukhbir Badal lost in Jalalabad; and finance minister Manpreet Badal was defeated in the Bathinda Rural seat. Capt. Amarinder Singh, the former chief minister, too lost in his Patiala stronghold. AAP candidates were the winners in all these places.

AAP benefited from the chaos in Punjab's politics generated after the Congress removed Amarinder in mid-September 2021. The lack of leadership led to party leaders squabbling among themselves, creating confusion among the voters. The Gandhi siblings, Priyanka and Rahul, the architects behind the change, did little to quell the confusion. By the time Channi was declared the party's CM face, just two weeks before the polls, the damage was already done.

Channi, the state's first Dalit chief minister, was banking heavily on his own Ramdasi/ Ravidasi community to back him. The community dominates the Doaba region of Punjab, which sends 23 legislators to the state assembly. In the event, the Congress

THE CONGRESS IS DOWN TO 18 SEATS, THE AKALI DAL TO THREE, A NEW LOW FOR BOTH PARTIES IN THE POST-MILITANCY ERA

managed to get just eight seats from this belt. The Dalit consolidation didn't happen, largely because of the massive infighting in the Congress and poor decision-making at the party headquarters in Delhi. In fact, the independent victor from Sultanpur Lodhi in the larger Doaba region, Rana Inder Pratap Singh, is the son of industrialist Rana Gurjit Singh, a cabinet minister in the Channi government.

In these polls, Congress was reduced to 18 seats from 80 in the previous assembly, melting the 38.5 per cent vote share in 2017 to less than 23 per cent now—a new low for the party in the post-militancy era. Their traditional rivals, the Akali Dal, continued to lose the confidence of the traditional *panthic* voters. The Badal family was burdened by the baggage of allegations related to incidents of sacrilege, drug smuggling and misuse of gurdwara finances—all of which they strongly deny. Meanwhile, their erstwhile ally, the BJP, continued to face voters' antipathy in the wake of the protracted farmers' protests. The outcome was the 100-year-old Akali Dal being reduced to three seats along with a lone seat for their ally BSP. With 18.4 per cent vote share, this is the worst performance ever for the *panthic* party.

The BJP did bag the Hindu-dominated Pathankot and Mukerian seats and maintained about 6 per cent of the vote share, but failed to win the confidence of even the core Hindu community elsewhere. Adding to the political churn in the run-up to the elections was a series of protests, ranging from teachers, anganwadi workers, contract workers etc., seeking regularisation of jobs.

All these circumstances helped AAP. And the anointment of Mann as the CM candidate allowed him to campaign freely in the state. Although a dedicated team from Delhi kept him sequestered from the media, the bigger message of "voting for broom" had already travelled to every nook and corner of the state, according to a top AAP leader in the state.

The stunning victory in the border state has, inevitably, unleashed the ambitions of party leaders for a larger national role for AAP. Raghav Chadha,